

AUDITION CALL · OPEN CALL

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

by Luigi Pirandello · translated by Edward Storer

A Village Players production

Lausanne, Switzerland

ABOUT THE PRODUCTION

The Village Players are casting Pirandello's metatheatrical comedy *Six Characters in Search of an Author* for a bold, minimalist staging in Lausanne. Eight live performers carry the production. The Boy and the Child are not cast — they are present as objects on the stage (a coat-and-chair, a wrapped bundle of white cloth). The rear wall lights up three times briefly across the evening; otherwise the stage is bare.

Each act has a single defining visual element: a circle of chairs in Act One; a two-level set (upper platform and lower floor) in Act Two; a single short fountain basin alone on stage in Act Three. The English of this version is contemporary — Storer's 1922 translation tightened for clarity, with the Step-Daughter's register pushed harder than polite English of a hundred years ago could carry. The first quarter of an hour is committed comedy. The last quarter of an hour is not.

AUDITIONS

WHERE	Lausanne — venue to be confirmed
WHEN	By appointment. Initial reads, then callbacks the following week.
WHAT TO PREPARE	A one-minute monologue of your choice (any era, any language we share) and the audition sides listed under your role of interest below.
SELF-TAPES	Accepted if travel to Lausanne is impractical for the first round.
CALLBACKS	Will involve cold reads from the production text and movement work.

CASTING PRINCIPLES

The production calls for eight performers across four Character tracks (Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son), one Manager track, and three Player tracks (each Player carrying multiple company roles within the world of the play). Casting is open across age, ethnicity, gender expression, and physical ability except where explicitly required by the role. The four Character actors do not double; the three Players are expected to move between roles quickly and visibly. The Manager is a single track, the audience proxy.

HOW TO APPLY

Send a headshot, a current CV, and a brief note (maximum 200 words) on why this play interests you and which role you wish to audition for, to: *casting [at] villageplayers [dot] ch*. Initial appointments will be confirmed within five working days. Please indicate any access requirements when you write.

THE ROLES — EIGHT TRACKS

What follows is one description per casting track, in the order they appear in the cast list. The character notes are working directorial sketches, not prescriptions — every actor brings something the page can't.

The Father

the brain of the family

160 speeches · 4,779 words across the production

Around fifty, heavy in body, pale-faced, with sharp blue eyes that go sharper the moment he is interrupted. The play's philosophical voice — a man arguing for his life by way of long speeches, always slightly ashamed afterwards of how much of himself he has had to admit. He must believe, in real time, every paradox he speaks. Not a lecturer; a man fighting to be allowed to exist as more than the worst hour of his life. Mellifluous when he controls the rhythm of his argument; violent the moment it breaks.

COLD-READ LINE

“Each one of us has within him a whole world of things, and to every one of us our own world.”

Act Three — the philosophical voice

AUDITION SIDES An Act One long speech on the many-sided conscience, or his Act Three 'Each one of us has within him a whole world of things'. Cold reads from the shop-scene confrontation in Act Two.

The Mother

silence that finally screams

36 speeches · 541 words across the production

A woman in modest black under a heavy widow's veil; beneath it, when she lifts it, a face the colour of wax. Crushed and terrified, as if pressed down by a weight too great to name. Silent for most of Act One — then, in Act Two, her presence becomes a sound, the only true unmediated cry in the play. Stillness is her language. Her line *It's taking place now. It happens all the time* should land like a stone learning to speak. Do not make her sympathetic in the easy way. She is heavier than that.

COLD-READ LINE

“It's taking place now. It happens all the time.”

Act Two — the only true unmediated cry in the play

AUDITION SIDES Her Act Two outburst at Madame Pace and her Act Three line 'It's taking place now. It happens all the time'. Strong physical presence; the role is mostly silent, then ruptures.

The Step-Daughter

speed and shame turned outward

106 speeches · 2,937 words across the production

Dashing, almost impudent, beautiful — in elegant mourning, black worn with style. Speed, shame turned outward, revenge wearing the dress of truth. She knows men look at her and uses the knowing; sex is her oldest weapon and her oldest wound, and she does not pretend either. Never apologetic — the performance is propulsion. Vulgar where vulgarity is the truth, arrogant where arrogance is armour. Her tenderness for the Child — for the bundle — must be unbearably real, so that her contempt for the Boy reads as the same wound, pointed in the opposite direction. She has a single projected moment in Act Two — the only audible projection in the production — where she speaks to her silent siblings as real children: tender to the Child, then violent with the Boy when she finds the revolver in his pocket. Below the screen, her live body stands silent, listening to her own recorded voice. The Father she neither pities nor forgives; she has not finished punishing him.

COLD-READ LINE

“And I came as mistress of the house.”

Act Two — the shop scene, the moment the wound speaks

AUDITION SIDES Her Act Two opening to the Child (the bundle) and her Madame-Pace scene; one of her exposure speeches from Act One. The role demands a register that moves between tenderness and vulgar fury without softening either.

The Son

the one who will not act

37 speeches · 775 words across the production

Twenty-two, tall, severe — at the edge of his own family as if he had walked onto the stage against his will, which in fact he did. The refuser. He calls himself *an unrealised character*, never given dramatic life by his author and refusing to ask for it now — yet he is on the stage, indissolubly bound to the chain. Play him quiet, cold, with the energy of someone who would leave if he could. Every line is a door closing. His mirror speech in Act Three — his likeness thrown back as a horrible grimace — is the only moment he allows himself a real cry. Make it count.

COLD-READ LINE

“I am an 'unrealised' character, dramatically speaking; and I feel ill at ease in their company.”

Act Three — the refuser defines himself

AUDITION SIDES His Act Three mirror speech and his refusal of the fountain scene. The role lives in stillness, contempt, and one real cry.

The Manager

the director on a deadline

194 speeches · 3,659 words across the production

Whatever an exhausted, competent theatre director at the end of a difficult week looks like — the schedule burning, faintly contemptuous of the playwright he has been forced to stage, faintly proud of his company. Pragmatic, cynical, slightly ridiculous, slightly brave. He treats the play in front of him as a job, until the job turns into something he does not have a name for, and then he tries to make a play out of it anyway. He is wrong in tone almost constantly, and right in instinct almost as often. Do not play him as a fool. Give him compassion. He is everyone in the audience who has ever been forced to make sense of someone else's grief on a deadline.

COLD-READ LINE

“I've lost a whole day over these people.”

Act Three — the curtain line

AUDITION SIDES His Act One anti-Pirandello rant and his final 'I've lost a whole day over these people'. Comic timing is essential; this is the audience-proxy role and the largest single track in the production.

Player 1

the man with all the hats

36 speeches · 422 words across the production

Carries the Leading Man, L'Ingénue, the Door-keeper, the Machinist, and the Third Actor — the largest collection of company roles in the production. The Leading Man's vanity is his spine in Act One: the cook's-cap argument with the Manager, the strut, the offence at being asked to wear a chef's hat in a serious play. The Door-keeper is small, apologetic, and lets the wrong six people in. The Machinist is the one who drops the curtain by mistake at the end of Act Two. Every transition between roles must be visible to the audience — the hat-toss, the change of bearing, the lift of the chin. Lean into the Leading Man early. The contrast with everything else will land harder later.

COLD-READ LINE

“Excuse me — must I really wear a cook's cap? I trained at the Conservatoire for this.”

Act One — the Leading Man's vanity, opening comedy

AUDITION SIDES The Leading Man's cook's-cap argument and any L'Ingénue moment. We will also ask for a brief Door-keeper line read. Strong comic register; quick visible transitions between three or four characters.

Player 2

the diva and the props

31 speeches · 285 words across the production

Carries the Leading Lady, the Property Man, the Fourth Actor, and the Second Lady Lead. The Leading Lady is offended at being made to play the Step-Daughter, and offended again when the Step-Daughter laughs at her attempt. The Property Man is the working theatre itself — the table, the folding screen, the pegs, the patience the director has personally exhausted. Two opposite registers in the same body: the vanity that costs nothing, and the labour that costs everything. Let the audience see her flip between them in the same scene. The hat-rack and the prop trolley are both her territory.

COLD-READ LINE

“A game! For heaven's sake — we are not children. We are serious actors. With training. With agents. With opinions on Stanislavski.”

Act Two — the Leading Lady refusing to play 'the game'

AUDITION SIDES The Leading Lady's offended response to playing the Step-Daughter, and a Property Man working-theatre beat. Two opposite registers — diva and labour — in the same body.

Player 3

the youngest, and Madame Pace

25 speeches · 286 words across the production

Carries the Juvenile Lead, the Prompter, Madame Pace, An Actor, and the Fifth Actor. The Juvenile Lead is eager and slightly ridiculous. The Prompter is in his box, sometimes a court stenographer, sometimes complaining about the draught. Then comes the production's most theatrically demanding moment: Madame Pace, an Italian-Swiss immigrant who runs an atelier off the rue de Bourg in Lausanne, an apparition summoned by the very arrangement of the stage — hats on pegs, a shop window with the sign *robes et manteaux*, a folding screen. Player 3 enters her costume the way an apparition enters a body — fat, bleach-blonde, rouged, dressed in comical black silk with a long silver chain at her waist ending in a pair of scissors. Half Italian, half French, ridiculous and grotesque. Play the comedy of her dialect at full strength; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength too. The audience laughs, and is then disgusted with itself for having laughed — that double sensation is the point of her.

COLD-READ LINE

“This is rank madness. Beautiful rank madness — but madness.”

Act One — the Juvenile Lead reacting to the Six's arrival

AUDITION SIDES A Juvenile Lead or Prompter beat — and a full Madame Pace audition: half French, half Italian, in costume if possible. Heavy character work; physical and dialect demands.

SILENT PRESENCES — NOT CAST

The Boy and the Child — the two youngest of the Six — are not played by performers in this production. The Boy is a black coat and a schoolboy's cap on a wooden chair, with a small leather satchel at the chair leg. The Child is a small wrapped bundle of white cloth, like a swaddling, carried and kissed and set down by the Step-Daughter and the Mother. They appear briefly in three short projections on the rear wall — for the entrance, for the Step-Daughter's Act Two monologue, and for ten seconds at the fountain in Act Three. Otherwise, the audience reads them from the chair and the bundle. We do not cast them; we build them.

Village Players · Lausanne · Six Characters in Search of an Author · Casting